Smithsonian Institute Travelling Exhibition Services

Usability Research & Recommendations

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Agenda

1 Summary

2 Problem areas

3 Recommendations

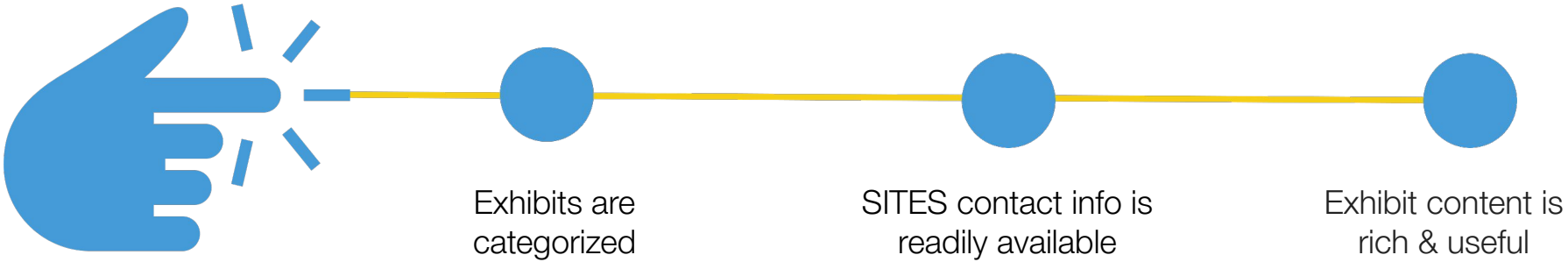
4 Research Methodology

5 Q & A

Summary

What works well currently

We interviewed **10 users** in SITES target audience and learned that:



What Can Be Improved

The login process is costing you leads

The site navigation is unintuitive

Exhibitions have poor discoverability

A comprehensive set of recommendations addressing these issues begins on slide 11.

Problem Areas

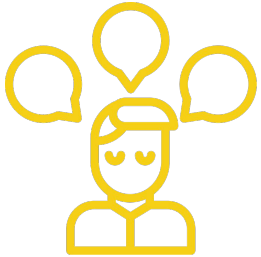
Logging in is a high-friction ask for users

- Creating an account is too much to ask
- There is no clear benefit to the process
- Users want the information up front

“I wouldn't log in to see basic information, by this time I would have given up and left.”

Navigating the site is difficult

- The content is not organized intuitively
- Filters are not usable without being logged in
- After log in, filters don’t always function



“I didn't consider budget at first because I thought this was a free program. I didn't see anything about payment until I logged in so I thought it was free.”

Certain content is hard to find

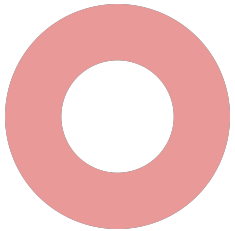
- The tour schedule requires 3 clicks to view
- Exhibit categories are unclear
- Content could be less complex overall

“Would be cool to view tour schedule without having to click a button”

Recommendations

Four ways to improve the user experience

Remove Login

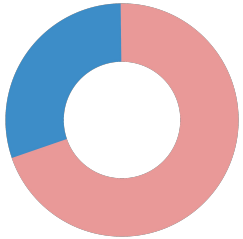


100 % Users

Users were not in favor of the Login

Users prefer to see information upfront

Improve Filters

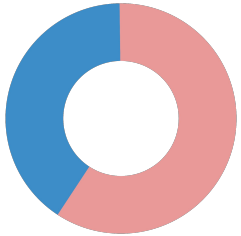


70 % Users

Users struggled finding tour schedules

Users faced issues with filters and tour info

Remove CTAs

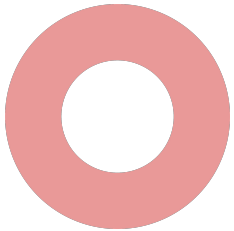


60% Users

Users were unable to understand some CTA's

CTA's like 'follow' didn't work and confused users

Clarify Content

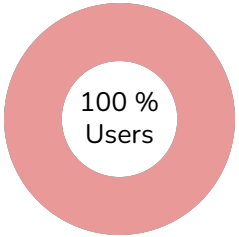


100 % Users

The content hierarchy confused users

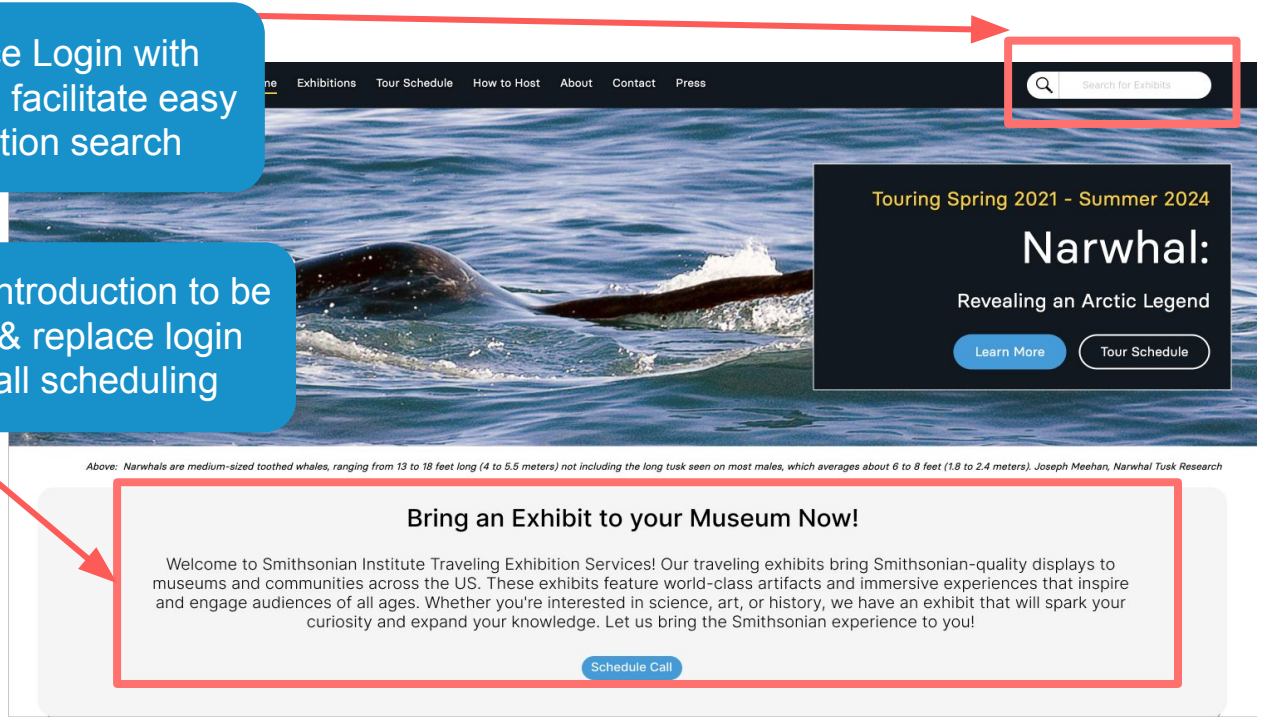
Users found some content confusing

Remove the Login to reduce user friction

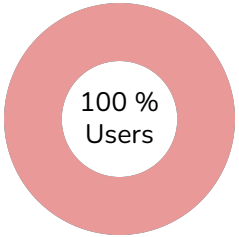


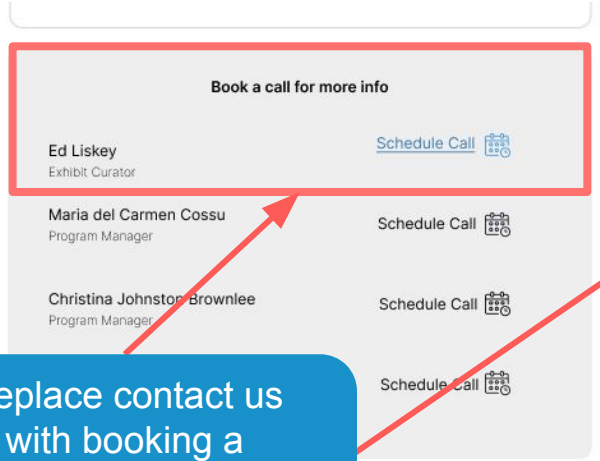
Replace Login with search to facilitate easy exhibition search

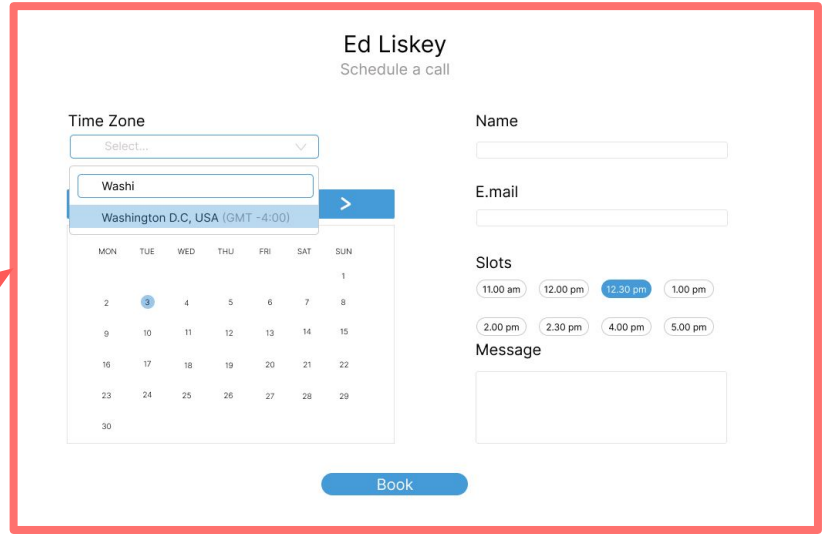
Change introduction to be clearer & replace login with call scheduling



“Schedule Call” integration generates leads



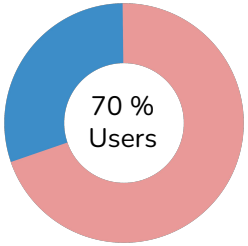




Replace contact us with booking a calendar, making email and name mandatory

Enhance the Filter Search

Allows users to undo the filter options. This is standard for filters.



A grayed out overlay with “Completely booked” signals to the user that an exhibit is unavailable.

Clear Filters | Hide Advanced Search

ng Feet: | Square Feet: | Security Level: | Availability

nder 100 | Under 700 | High | From

0 - 200 | 700 - 1000 | Moderate/High

0 - 300 | 1000 - 2000 | Moderate | To

300 & Above | 2000 - 3000 | Limited/Moderate

3000 & Above | Limited

Only Show Open Slots:

No

The Only Show Open Slots toggle lets the user see only what is available for booking

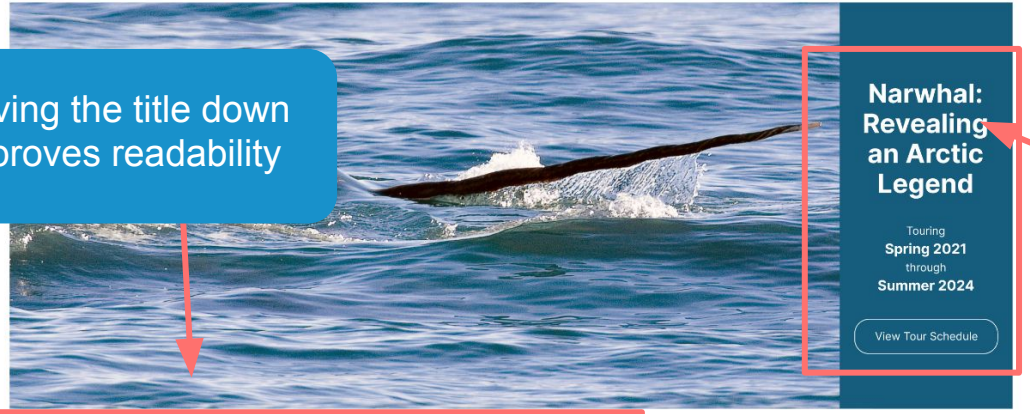
American Democracy: A Great Leap of Faith — Completely booked

Billie Holiday at Sugar Hill: Photographs by Jerry Dantzic — Completely booked

Caribbean Indigenous Resistance / Resistencia indígena del Caribe... — Completely booked

Dolores / F — Completely booked

Moving the title down improves readability



By making the title font larger, it draws the user's eye

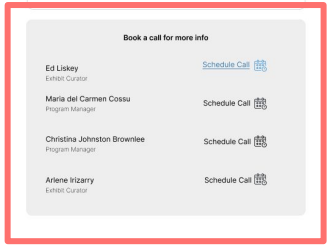
Narwhal: Revealing an Arctic Legend

Currently on View at:
The Putnam Museum & Science Center , Davenport, Iowa - 2/4/2023 - 4/30/2023

What can Narwhal tell us about the future of our oceans?
Narwhal: Revealing an Arctic Legend offers insights into the relationship between narwhals and our changing global climate through the work of Arctic researchers and experience from members of the Inuit community. This exhibition features a 16-foot fiberglass model of an adult male narwhal suspended from the ceiling. The model is surrounded by banners, graphic panels, objects cases and models that involve audiences in the narwhal story.

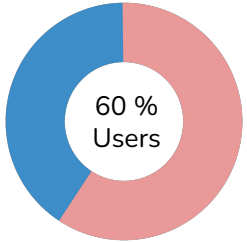
"This celebration of these magical creatures and the stewardship of the Inuit people advances our mission to 'inspire our diverse community to learn about and care for our world and all its people'."

- Rachael Mullins, President and CEO, Putnam Museum and Science Center (Smithsonian Affiliate)



Removing the buttons helps keep the user focused on finding the exhibit information

Move Tour Schedule to Main Exhibit Page



Crucial scheduling information is easy to jump to on the same page

Exhibition Documents

Arctic Legend #01 - Exhibition Prospectus

se download the prospectus for a list of content and features, hosting requirements,

Tour Schedule

Exhibition:

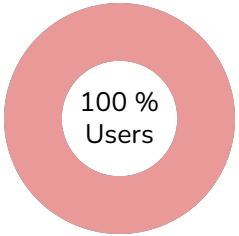
Narwhal: Revealing an Arctic Legend

Show Past Events:

No

EXHIBITION	CITY	STATE	VENUE	STATUS	OPENING DATE	CLOSING DATE
Narwhal: Revealing an Arctic Legend	Davenport	Iowa	The Putnam Museum & Science Ce...	Booked	2/4/2023	4/30/2023
Narwhal: Revealing an Arctic Legend				Open - Reduced Fee: $10,000	5/20/2023	8/13/2023

Add More Media



Installation Support:

- Detailed design plans and installation instructions
- Genie Superlift and attachment system for suspended narwhal model
- Installation videos

Education Materials:

- Docent training materials
- Teacher activities and resources
- Distance learning materials from Smithsonian Learning Lab

Venue Provided Elements:

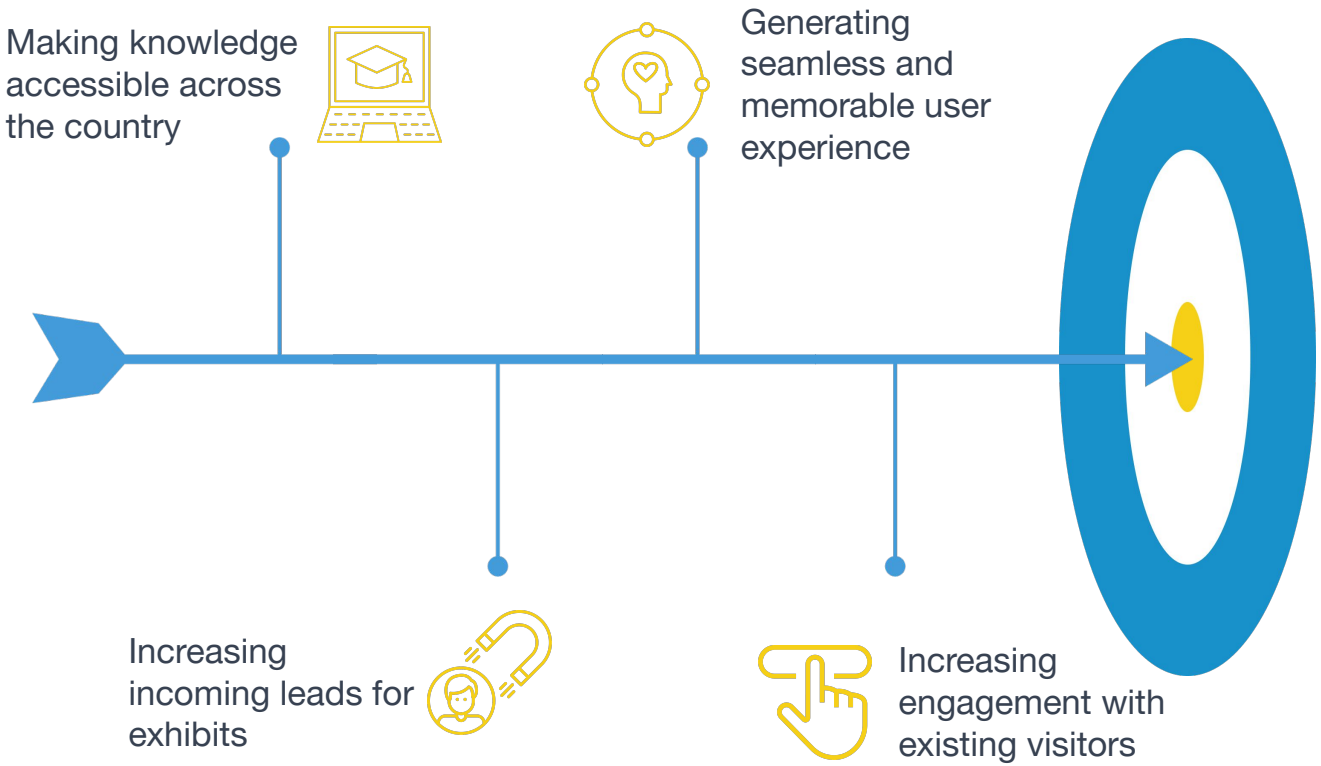
- Three staff for exhibition installation

Organized by the Smithsonian Institution Traveling Exhibition Service in collaboration with the Smithsonian's National Museum of Natural History

Users want more media and less text

Methodology

Goals for UX Research of SITES



The User Persona of our Interviewees

User testing process funnel

Scripts · · · · · · **Recruitment** · · · · · · **Schedule Interviews**

10 **User Testing** · · · · · · · **3** **Main Issues** · · · · · · · **4** **Recommendations**

Prioritization of User Issues

REACH + **IMPACT** + **CONFIDENCE**

How many people will this feature affect within a given time period?

How much will this impact individual users?

How confident are the researchers about the impact and reach scores?

0 3

Severity Rating

Questions?

Appendix

All User Problems

*View by clicking this: **All User Findings.** There you will find detailed information and data points from our research.*

Splitting of categories between top of the page and bottom is confusing	2	2	2	6	"Why are some of the categories at the bottom"		Homepage
Titles of some of the categories are not understandable	3	3	3	9	"What do they mean by build it yourself"		Homepage
The banner is distracting and adds to confusion wrto the website	2	1	3	6			Homepage
Too much content to read, details like space taken up, secuity etc missing	3	3	3	9			Exhibit page
Post a question seems less relavent	3	3	3	9	"I would post if only I could see what others have written and who will answer these"		Exhibit page
Follow isn't unclear	2	1	3	6	"This looks like I can follow the exhibit and it's updates maybe"		Exhibit page
Pictorial representation of setup would have been very helpful	3	3	3	9		could be from previos exhibits as well	Exhibit page
Content confusion in terms of "running feet", "security type"	2	3	2	7			Exhibit page
Viewing tour schedule is unclear with the dates and the unresponsive toggle	3	3	3	9			Exhibit page
Users find the login frustrating	3	3	3	9		1/3 would share details for a newsletter	Post login
User struggle with the filter and take a while to understand how it works	3	2	3	8			Post login

Moderated User Interview Process

View tasks and interview script by clicking on 'interview script', and consent form by clicking on 'consent form'

Decide tasks and build interview script

Run 4 Pilot tests with script on Zoom and finalise script

Users sign Consent form before interview

Users interviewed on Zoom/In-person and go through tasks using Think-aloud method and screen share

Interview is recorded and notes are taken as observer, which are then analysed using RIC.

Participant recruitment

View by form by clicking on 'recruitment form'

Setup the recruitment form

Circulate within School of Information Pratt

Recruit participants from Museum/Library program with experience working with these institutes

Reach out to existing SITES users

Set up User Interviews with both audiences

Competitive Analysis

Organization	Login Option	Space Required	Contents/Items	Crates	Trucks	Staffing	Load In/Out	Booking
SITES	Yes	No	Yes	No	No	Yes	No	Email
NatGeo	No	No	Yes	No	No	No	No	Web Form
AMNH	No	Yes	No	No	No	No	No	Web Form
BK Museum	No	Yes	Yes	No	No	No	No	Email
World Touring Ex	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Email
Imagine	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	No	No	No	Email

Columns C-H are information provided by the site about the traveling exhibit.

Link: Full Competitive Analysis with References

Thank you